



Encounter

Before European contact, Indigenous societies in Latin America ranged from mobile hunter-gatherers to complex empires. These differences shaped how groups interacted with European invaders.

The conquest's impacts continue to influence Latin American society today.

Indigenous Social Organization



Nonsedentary Peoples

Mobile hunter-gatherers like the Chichimecas had simple social structures.



Semisedentary Peoples

Groups like the Tupi combined farming with mobility using shifting cultivation.



Fully Sedentary Peoples

Aztecs, Incas, and Mayas built permanent settlements with hierarchical systems.



Aztec and Inca Civilizations

Aztec Empire

Based in Tenochtitlan, the Mexica built power through tribute extraction and military expansion.

Religious legitimacy came through human sacrifice.



Inca Empire

Governed Andean highlands through centralized bureaucracy and extensive road systems.

The *mita* labor system and divine kingship maintained control.





Iberian Background: Crusade and Colonization



Reconquista

Centuries of religious conflict to expel Muslim rule from Iberia.



Catholic Monarchs

Queen Isabella saw expansion as continuation of sacred mission.



1492

Granada falls; Columbus's voyage opens Americas to Iberian intervention.



1500

Portugal stumbles into Brazil, initially marginal to their interests.

Spanish Conquest Strategies

1

Alliances

Cortés partnered with indigenous groups against Aztecs.

2

Technology

Horses, steel, and cannons provided tactical advantages.

3

Disease

Smallpox devastated Indigenous populations.

4

Division

Exploited internal conflicts like the Inca civil war.



The Encomienda and Early Colonial Order



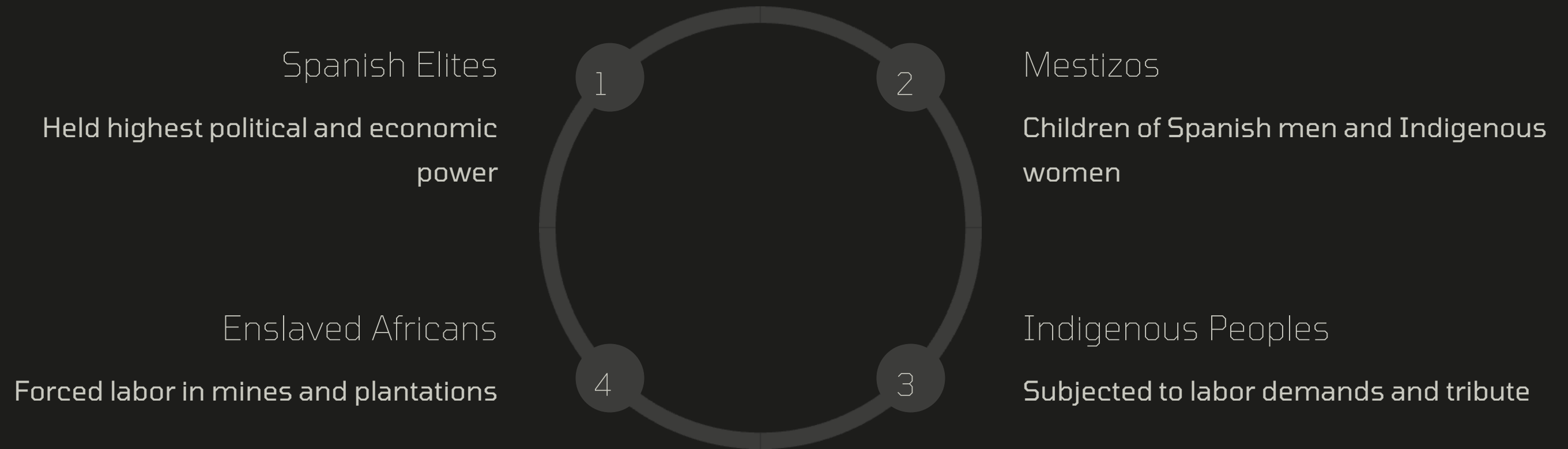
The encomienda system created a feudal-style hierarchy. Encomenderos were supposed to protect and Christianize Indigenous subjects.

In practice, the system led to extreme exploitation.

Brazil: From Trade Outpost to Plantation Economy



Cultural Fusion and Social Hierarchies



Colonial society quickly became multiethnic. This racial and gendered hierarchy became the basis for colonial caste systems.



Religion as Tool and Battlefield

Conversion Campaigns

Churches built atop sacred sites. Mass baptisms performed. Indigenous beliefs suppressed.

Religious Defenders

Bartolomé de Las Casas and others criticized abuses. Religious orders pushed for reforms.

Syncretic Practices

Catholicism merged with Indigenous beliefs. Distinct Latin American religious cultures emerged.